Kabuli; both wanted to lead the rebellion and ‘each lay in ambush for the other’. This unproductive state of affairs ended when Masum Kabuli bribed his competitor’s young male love to poison Sharafuddin’s opium.

Many others among the mutineers, if not actively plotting against each other, were far less committed to their cause than the imperial troops seem to have been. Soon after arriving in the east, for example, Todar Mal noticed that his colleague in the finance department, Shah Mansur, was demanding taxes from Bengal even while the rebellion raged. The raja complained to the emperor, who put his over-scrupulous vizier in prison. Promptly, many deserters in Bengal returned to the imperial fold.

Such reneging on the revolution was not taken lightly by the rebel commanders. Abul Fazl describes one of them, called Arab, killing a lapsed mutineer and drinking ‘some of his blood’. And yet, no matter how terrifying these warlords, they had begun to lose their authority. Foremost amongst them was Baba Khan Qaqshal, the acknowledged leader of the whole enterprise, who had developed a terrible case of gangrene: ‘every day he put two [seers] of flesh into the wound to feed the maggots’,[31] while blaming his disgusting fate on his breach of loyalty.

~

The Bengal rebellion was losing some of its steam, therefore, when, in late December 1580, Akbar’s half-brother Mirza Muhammad Hakim sent two successive contingents, one led by a man considered to be the very ‘sword of his army’, into Hindustan.

Once again, Akbar kept his cool; though Abul Fazl, in his aggravation, can hardly control his metaphors. What could Hakim be thinking? ‘Little did he know that a trickle of water is useless against a raging fire, and scratching is not an effective treatment against chronic haemorrhoids.’[32] Indeed, Akbar’s men in Punjab – led by yet another of his most trusted generals, Man Singh – made quick work of Hakim’s troops. His crack swordsman was wounded and died.

Then, in January 1581, exactly one year after the Qaqshals mutinied, news arrived that Mirza Hakim had ridden into Hindustan himself. Until now, Akbar had insisted he wouldn’t make hasty decisions about Hakim’s incursions. ‘A son can be acquired,’ he would say, ‘but how can a brother be